



EVERREADY FAMILY

The Executor's First 30 Days

Someone named you executor. You've never done this before. Start here.

What it is

A one-month checklist for a brand-new executor: what to secure in the first three days, who to call in week one, which papers to hunt in week two, and how to set the legal process in motion by week four — in plain order, one step at a time.

Who it's for

Anyone who was just named executor — or just learned they will be — and doesn't know where to begin. You do not need a law degree. You need the steps in the right order, and someone honest about what can wait.

How to use it

Work it in order; the sequence is the point. Check off each step as you finish it, keep everything in one folder from day one, and let the checklist carry the worry so you don't have to.

"I was executor for my mother's estate. This is what I wish someone had handed me."

— Bill Morton, EverReady Family

A free first step from EverReady Family.

Ready for whatever comes.

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Three things to know first

1. The estate pays its own bills.

You are not personally responsible for their debts. The estate pays what it owes, in the right order, from its own funds. Your job is the process: gather, protect, pay, distribute, report.

2. Slow is safe in week one.

Almost nothing has to happen today. The irreversible mistakes — giving things away, throwing papers out, paying the wrong bill — all come from rushing. The checklist keeps you ahead of the real deadlines without hurrying you into the fake ones.

3. One folder, one list, one log.

Every paper, every phone call, every hour you spend goes into one place starting today. Your future self — and the court, and the family — will thank you for it in month six.

Named executor? Start on the next page. The first three days are shorter than you fear.



DAYS 1–3

Secure and stabilize

The first seventy-two hours have one job: nothing gets lost, nothing gets worse. Everything else waits its turn.

- **Secure the home.** Locks work, valuables and important papers are safe, insurance stays paid. Tell a trusted neighbor if it'll sit empty.
- **Care for the living.** Anyone who depended on the person — spouse, child, parent, pet — gets arranged first. Paperwork waits.
- **Find the will.** Desk, filing cabinet, safe deposit box, the attorney's office. Don't panic if it takes a few days.
- **Order 8–12 certified death certificates** through the funeral home. Banks, insurers, and the court will all ask.
- **Start one list.** A notebook, a notes app, one folder — everything about this job goes in one place from today.

DO NOT DO THESE THIS WEEK

give anything away · throw anything away · pay their debts from your pocket · promise anyone anything



WEEK 1

Get professional backup

You were never supposed to do this alone. This is the week you line up the people whose job it is to help.

- **Schedule a probate attorney consultation.** You want someone who does probate and estate administration — not a generalist. Bring what you know; they'll guide the rest.
- **Confirm Social Security was notified** (the funeral home usually handles this).
- **Set up mail forwarding** to your address so nothing gets missed.
- **Get the estate's EIN** (free from the IRS website) — the estate needs its own tax ID.
- **Keep paying the essentials:** mortgage, homeowner's insurance, utilities on the house. Hold everything else.

One caution that saves executors every week: don't pay a single one of their debts out of your own pocket, and don't promise family members anything yet — not furniture, not money, not timelines. "I don't know yet, and I'll tell everyone at the same time" is a complete and honest answer.



WEEK 2

Follow the paper

An estate is mostly paper. This week you find out where it all lives — before anyone needs it urgently.

- **Hunt the documents:** will, deeds, titles, bank and investment statements, insurance policies, tax returns, business papers.
- **Check the safe deposit box** — call the bank first; many states require a court order or a specific procedure to open it.
- **Search their email** for "account," "policy," and "statement" — it's often the map to the online accounts.
- **Start the asset list.** Walk the house, photograph room by room. Nothing leaves the house until it's listed.

Photograph first, decide later. The formal inventory comes soon enough — this week is about knowing what exists, and making sure nothing walks away before it's written down.



WEEKS 3–4

Set the process in motion

By the end of the first month, the legal machinery should be turning and the family should know how this will go. That calm you're creating? This is where it comes from.

- **File for probate** with your attorney (or confirm the plan and timeline with them).
- **Begin the formal inventory** — the court will require it, and everything downstream depends on it.
- **Start your time log.** Date, what you did, how long. Your compensation depends on it.
- **Write the family letter.** What's happening, how long it takes, nothing decided yet, everything visible.
- **Put every deadline in your phone** — with reminders two weeks early, not the day of.

The family letter matters more than it looks. Most estate fights don't start over money — they start over silence. One honest letter, sent to everyone at once, prevents more arguments than any document in this checklist.



THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

It's the estate's job, not yours

You are not personally responsible for their debts. The *estate* pays its own bills, in the right order, from its own funds. Your job is the process: gather, protect, pay, distribute, report. Follow the process and you're protected.

Thirty days from now you will know where the will is, who your attorney is, what exists, and what happens next. That is no small thing — that's an executor doing the job right.

WHEN YOU'RE READY

The next step, when you want it

This checklist covers the first month. When you're ready for the full step-by-step, the **Executor's Kit** walks the whole process the same plain way — the paperwork, the accounts, the formal inventory, the deadlines, and the family conversations — one step at a time, in order. There's no hurry and no pressure; it's there when the first month is behind you and you want the rest of the map.



Ready for whatever comes.